

Truth and usefulness



Peirce's pragmatism was enthusiastically taken up by his friend and Harvard University colleague William James. James had a very readable literary style (his brother was the novelist Henry James) and helped to popularize Peirce's ideas, as well as elaborating on them. While Peirce had concerned himself primarily with the meaning of a statement or term, James examined the idea of truth. For him, a statement can be considered true if it provides a valid explanation, allows predictions or gives an insight: if it is useful and does what we require it to do. He gives the example of a man lost in a forest who finds a path: he can choose to believe that it will lead

him to safety and follow it out of the forest, or decide that it won't and simply stay where he is and starve. Either way, his action makes his belief true. James makes a distinction between true beliefs, those that are useful to the believer, and facts: 'Truths emerge from facts ... facts themselves are not true. They simply are. Truth is the function of the beliefs that start and terminate among them.'